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Monk and the Monster



So there is a whiff of Tiananmen Square from Lhasa. After the crushed 'Saffron Revolution' in Burma, the monk and the jackbooted monster are back in the headlines, if not in the consciousness of those who are not in thrall of the Beijing miracle.

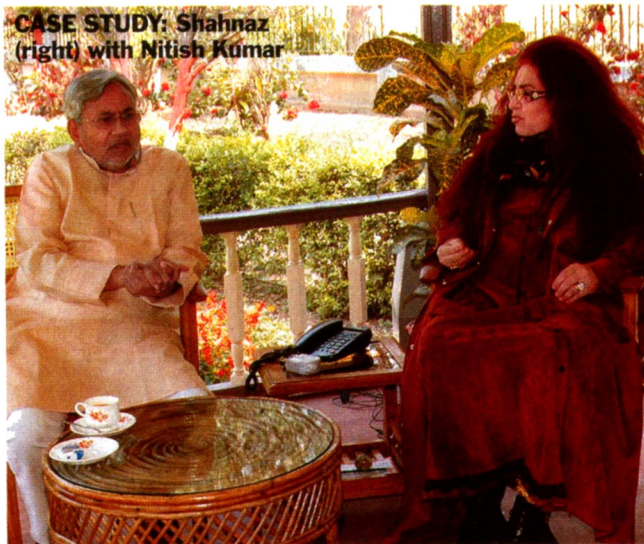
Once again, resistance looks fragile, and the tyranny of the paranoid is poised to prevail. And pitted against each other are two powerful images of the times. Tibet chic continues to colonise freedom junkies from Hollywood to Delhi. The Dalai Lama, unarguably the most popular monk in the world, has brought the meaning of suffering from the Buddhist text to the trendiest drawing rooms of the world. He has made suffering cool. He has made Tibet the inevitable destination for the neo-compassionate. The other image is formidable—and familiar. China: the thunder from the East that rattles the waning powers of the West. China: the fairytale of modernisation. Hasn't the fastest growing economy in the world banished Mao to the souvenir shop—and Marx to the McDonald's? Oh, it is glorious to be rich in the People's Republic. Learn it from the Chinese—aren't we tired of that refrain from the seminar room? China is steeped in a million superlatives. Romancing the Dragon is the new show in town.

We are witnessing a clash between two stereotypes—and this clash is far removed from reality. India, home to the exiled Dalai Lama, still tries to achieve a fine balance between moral obligation and national interest. Today, it seems, national interest demands subtle subjugation—or indifference. Perhaps that is why the Tibet cause has become the prerogative of the usual socialist suspects and other professional romanticists of the Lost Shangri-La. What Lhasa magnifies is the deepest paranoia of the Chinese regime, which may have abandoned the textbook gods of communism but not the Leninist party apparatus. Beyond the supermarket, invisible to the aficionados of 'the Chinese way of building a brand new future', is the Gulag of the East. In the middle kingdom of happiness, questions are still banned. Progress requires the permanent suspension of conscience. And Lhasa erupted on the eve of the Beijing Olympic Games, an event that will showcase the awesome Chinese efficiency and precision for global appreciation. Lhasa became a surprise preview; the monks didn't wait for the gymnasts to finish their performance. They shattered the idyll, and the horror beneath the glitz was exposed. The Chairman will be pleased. The Cultural Revolution lives on.



SAURABH SINGH

CASE STUDY: Shahnaz (right) with Nitish Kumar



Family Ties Turn Sour

PATNA The mysterious death of Sameer Hussain, son of noted beautician and businesswoman Shahnaz Hussain, has taken a new twist. Following Shahnaz's petition to Nitish Kumar, the chief minister has recommended a CBI inquiry into the death of the musician who was also the president of his mother's company which has numerous beauty clinics in India and abroad. Although the Bihar Home Department has already issued a notification to this effect, the CBI is yet to take a decision on investigating the death.

Sameer was found dead on January 6 this year outside his in-laws house in Maqbool Apartments on Exhibition Road in the city. It is not clear whether he jumped off their third floor flat or fell accidentally. Although the police had found no suicide note following his death, there are reports suggesting that Sameer was depressed for some family reasons. His wife Rabia and daughter

Husna had gone to Dhanbad to visit their maternal uncle at the time of the incident. Sameer was also an aspiring singer and performer. He had cut his own album about three years ago, although it was not a success.

Apparently anguished over her mother-in-law blaming her for Sameer's death, Rabia has broken her silence. She says she will welcome a probe "as long as the sleuths also try to find out the circumstances that led to my husband's death". She insists that "Sameer and her mother had a strained relationship that worsened after Shahnaz remarried. My husband had been crestfallen since then."

Sameer was Shahnaz's only son. "She had given no stakes to my husband in her business empire. That also frustrated him to the core," says Rabia. Meanwhile, Rabia is expecting her second child, whose father's death still remains an unsolved mystery.

by Amitabh Srivastava